
SESSION 3C

HEAVEN AND HELL

HEAVEN, OUR TRUE HOME

Our most fundamental need is for love. Without love, life becomes unlivable. But love demands an eternity. Built right into love itself is the call for forever. And yet our love runs into the wall of death. Is the universe, then, just a hoax and a joke?

We discover in the pages of the Bible, and uniquely so, that because the God who created us is himself a triune community of love, our fundamental craving for love is met by the very core of God's character—for God is love. We have an infinite craving for love, because it is meant to be satisfied by the infinite love of God. Heaven is, therefore, a relational reality. At the core of Christianity you have the father and the son in relationship. And heaven is simply joining in the eternal fellowship of the triune God:



JOHN 14:2-3 (ESV)

²In my Father's house are many rooms. If it were not so, would I have told you that I go to prepare a place for you? ³And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again and will take you to myself, that where I am you may be also.

Salvation is all about a restored relationship that goes on forever. If there's love and salvation, then there's heaven to continue that relationship eternally.

How does the idea of heaven presented here match with your understanding of your own salvation?

HELL, A RELATIONAL REALITY

We need to understand hell, too, in a relational way, rather than in a punitive way. If you see hell purely in its punitive form, it leads to the problem of disproportionality: a small crime that meets with oversized punishment.

We understand heaven as a place where we will be in relationship with God, returned as children to our heavenly Father. We must understand hell in this relational dynamic too. If you were antagonistic to God all your life, if you could care less about eternity, and if you were not rich toward God, then God's loving response is to honor your decision to remain separate from him.

As strange as this may sound, hell is a final manifestation of what love does, because love is not coercive. Love does not force itself; love concedes defeat. And love must ultimately take the risk of being rejected.

And within each human being exists the temptation of prideful autonomy that whispers, "You don't need this. To hell with this." As Milton in *Paradise Lost* put it on the lips of the serpent, "Better to rule in hell than to serve in heaven."

From these premises it follows directly that the Divine labour to redeem the world cannot be certain of succeeding as regards every individual soul. Some will not be redeemed. There is no doctrine which I would more willingly remove from Christianity than this, if it lay in my power. But it has the full support of Scripture and, specially, of our Lord's own words; it has always been held by Christianity; and it has the support of reason. If a game is played, it must be possible to lose it. If the happiness of a creature lies in self-surrender, no one can make that surrender but himself (though many can help him to make it) and he may refuse. I would pay any price to be able to say truthfully 'All will be saved.' But my reason retorts 'Without their will, or with it?' If I say 'Without their will' I at once perceive a contradiction; how can the supreme voluntary act of self-surrender be involuntary? If I say 'With their will,' my reason replies 'How if they will not give in?'¹

- C.S. Lewis, *The Problem of Pain*

I willingly believe that the damned are, in one sense, successful, rebels to the end; that the doors of hell are locked on the inside. I do not mean that the ghosts may not wish to come out of hell, in the vague fashion wherein an envious man 'wishes' to be happy: but they certainly do not will even the first preliminary stages of that self-abandonment through which alone the soul can reach any good.²

- C.S. Lewis, *The Problem of Pain*

People who cultivate a heart of rebellion against God their whole lives, who rebel against any notion that God has a claim over their lives, will not welcome being subject to God. For people who have cultivated this autonomy, this rebellion, this pride, this narcissism, heaven will not be heaven.

The characteristic of lost souls is 'their rejection of everything that is not simply themselves'. Our imaginary egoist has tried to turn everything he meets into a province or appendage of the self. The taste for the other, that is, the very capacity for enjoying good, is quenched in him except in so far as his body still draws him into some rudimentary contact with an outer world. Death removes this last contact. He has his wish—to lie wholly in the self and to make the best of what he finds there. And what he finds there is Hell.

...

And people often talk as if the 'annihilation' of a soul were intrinsically possible. In all our experience, however, the destruction of one thing means the emergence of something else. Burn a log, and you have gases, heat and ash. To have been a log means now being those three things. If souls can be destroyed, must there not be a state of having been a human soul? And is not that, perhaps, the state which is equally well described as torment, destruction, and privation? You will remember that in the parable, the saved go to a place prepared for them, while the damned go to a place never made for men at all. To enter heaven is to become more human than you ever succeeded in being on earth; to enter hell, is to be banished from humanity. What is cast (or casts itself) into hell is not a man: it is 'remains'. To be a complete man means to have the passions obedient to the will and the will offered to God: to have been a man—to be an ex-man or 'damned ghost'—would presumably mean to consist of a will utterly centred in its self and passions utterly uncontrolled by the will.³

- C.S. Lewis, *The Problem of Pain*

Review to C.S. Lewis passages and answer the questions below.

What is your response to C.S. Lewis' description of who goes to hell?

¹ Lewis, C.S. *Problem of Pain*. New York: HarperCollins, 2009. Location 1319. Kindle edition.

² Lewis, C.S. *Problem of Pain*. New York: HarperCollins, 2009. Location 1423. Kindle edition.

³ Lewis, C.S. *Problem of Pain*. New York: HarperCollins, 2009. Location 1370. Kindle edition.

Reflect on C.S. Lewis' definition of what it means to be a complete man. What implication does this have on how a heaven-bound person should be living now here on Earth?

Read the passages below about God's heart and answer the question below.



EZEKIEL 33:11 (ESV)

¹¹ Say to them, As I live, declares the Lord God, I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked, but that the wicked turn from his way and live; turn back, turn back from your evil ways, for why will you die, O house of Israel?

1 TIMOTHY 2:3-4 (ESV)

³ This is good, and it is pleasing in the sight of God our Savior, ⁴ who desires all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth.

2 PETER 3:9 (ESV)

⁹ The Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise as some count slowness, but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance.

What do the above passages reveal about God's heart?

TRAJECTORY OF LIFE

The contrast between heaven and hell can occasionally seem too dramatic compared with the much smaller differences we see among people. You may have a friend you grew up with, and both of you had decent upbringings and were good citizens. Then you become a Christian and your friend doesn't. You're learning to worship. You're learning to pray. You're learning to confess your sins. You're learning to be aware of God's gaze upon your life. But you look at your friend, and fail to see any difference that's on the order of heaven and hell dimensions. Yet the Bible teaches that whatever difference in the trajectory of one versus the other continues forever. The angle may diverge only very little in this life, but extended eternally, the difference would be infinite.

It is a serious thing to live in a society of possible gods and goddesses, to remember that the dullest and most uninteresting person you talk to may one day be a creature which, if you saw it now, you would be strongly tempted to worship, or else a horror and a corruption such as you now meet, if at all, only in a nightmare. All day long we are, in some degree, helping each other to one or other of these destinations. [...] There are no *ordinary* people. You have never talked to a mere mortal. Nations, cultures, arts, civilization—these are mortal, and their life is to ours as the life of a gnat. But it is immortals whom we joke with, work with, marry, snub, and exploit—immortal horrors or everlasting splendours. ⁴

- C.S. Lewis, *The Weight of Glory*

⁴ Lewis, C.S. *Weight of Glory*. New York: Macmillan, 1949. p. 9.

What is the trajectory of your life? Have you sensed a difference in terms of your heaven-boundedness since becoming Christian?

As a Christian, what new values, feelings and habits have grown in you that you would not have cultivated without Christ?

WHAT IS MY REALITY?

Going back to the story of the rich fool, why would he be so rich toward himself? Why would he be so lavish with thoughts and plans about this life and his belly, and yet so unconcerned and clueless about his eternal destiny?

It's probably because of the huge harvest. The sheer amount of wealth represented by his harvest presented a joyous problem. "I have so much, I need to start building barns. I need to do this and that. I need to find some tax shelters. Now that people know I have all this grain, I need to build a fence. I need to buy some insurance." The thought of all the grain he had to store up and keep safe for the rest of the years of his life drove him to frenzied planning and activity. This occupied his vision for his life, crowding out all else. To the extent that this was the only thing he was responding to, this became all of reality for him. No other considerations had any hold or claim on him. All else became unreal.

Some people say, "I don't see God. I don't get all this God talk. I am having a hard time experiencing any traction with the gospel message." There's a lot of reality that's every bit as real as the bus that drives by on the street, but it requires certain conditions to detect and sometimes even training to see. When a doctor looks at an MRI image, what to me are unintelligible blotches are meaningful to him. His knowledge and training enable him to see things that are there, which my untrained eyes cannot make sense of.

We all have a bias about what we count as real. Our pride resists the idea of God. Our narcissism makes us hypersensitive to ourselves and to our very small and narrow ego-sphere. Our anxieties and desires cloud our perceptions. Our greed fills our minds with outlandish fantasies. With all this and more going on inside of us, genuine knowledge of God may occasionally hit us, but it is hard to sustain our attention.

The Bible addresses our difficulty with recognizing spiritual truths:



ISAIAH 57:15 (ESV)

¹⁵ For thus says the One who is high and lifted up, who inhabits eternity, whose name is Holy:
"I dwell in the high and holy place, and also with him who is of a *contrite* and *lowly* spirit, to revive the spirit of the lowly, and to revive the heart of the contrite."

Contrite and lowly of spirit: this was what we saw in the scene at the cross we considered earlier. A criminal rebuking the other criminal, saying, "Look we are sinners." Those are the conditions upon which spiritual realities start to come into focus. God is revealed to you when you come before him a humble and contrite sinner. Narcissism, pride, autonomy, obsession with materialism and sensuality – these threaten our ability to encounter God. These must be dialed down deliberately, just as one must turn off the lights in order to better see the stars in the night sky. We must approach God in his word and in our prayers with the attitude of contrition and humility.

What are some ways you can better grasp spiritual realities and alter your usual sense of what's real?

How does your life measure up to the truths: Life is short, eternity is long, death is certain. Only what is done for the Lord will last?